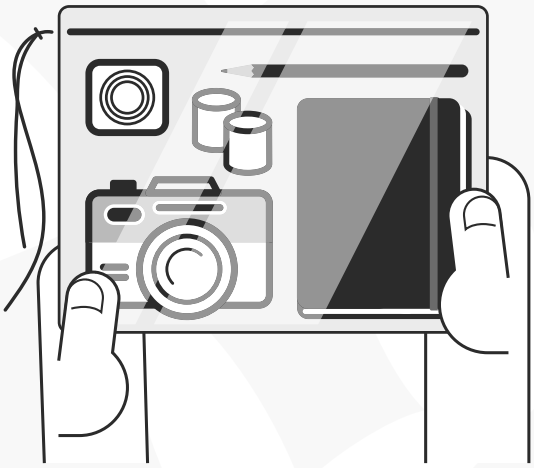

Cultural Probes

Before you design a mobile app, a professional online platform or an interactive experience such as an immersive museum exhibition, it's essential to understand users and the contexts in which they will use your design. People are experts in their own lives and experiences. As designers, we can use cultural probes in the early stages of a project to inspire and to build empathy with our users. This template gives you the steps required to design cultural probes and take your designs to the next level.

What are Cultural Probes?

Cultural probes are packages of tasks you give to a target group in a design project to get a better understanding of their lives. The probe tasks are often small creative challenges—writing a diary or taking photos, for example—that not only help you gather information but also provide inspiration for the design process. You typically give the probe to your participants and ask them to complete the tasks on their own over a period of several days. The way you design the probe, and the tasks it contains, are crucial if you want to sensitize users to their own context, elicit the desired information and playfully invite users to share rich clues about their lives.

Best Practice

Stage 1: Prepare Your Probes

- Determine what you need to learn from the probe. The trick is to remain broad enough to inspire design while remaining focused on the design problem. For example, if you want to design an app to get asthma patients out to exercise, you may need insights into their social lives as well as their walking habits. In such a case, you could design a task that asks them to take pictures when they are out for a walk or a visitor book where people visiting could write a short greeting.

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- Decide which type of probe kit matches your target group. Depending on your goal and the users themselves, some kinds of probe kits and tasks will be more successful than others. If you want to give your probes to commuters, design a probe kit they can easily take on their commute. Regarding the tasks in your probe kit, you could ask participants to write and draw about events or objects in their context, photograph their situation at set times each day or map their daily routines and the feelings they experience throughout.
- Develop your probes. Start with tasks that don't require too much from the participants—e.g., providing factual information or taking pictures. Later, they can solve more speculative tasks—e.g., describing an idea for a fantastic exercise motivator. Decide whether the participants should complete each task at specific times or on particular days or if you want to leave that up to them. All tasks should take no longer than 5–10 minutes to complete each day and be completed over a 1-week period.
- Plan how you will deliver and collect the probes. We recommend that you deliver and collect the probe kits in person to show your dedication and commitment to participants as individuals. You'll probably want to include your participants in an ideation session as part of the follow-up. So, it's essential that you also consider how and when you would like to do that and ask your participants for their involvement as you deliver or collect the probes.

Stage 2: Deliver & Collect Your Probes

- Deliver your probes to participants. Let your participants know when you'll be back to collect the probes and then leave them to get on with the tasks they contain. As your participants carry out the tasks, they will generate rich insights you can later use as input for your design process.
- Collect your probes. Once participants have been with the probes for the designated period, personally collect them. Lay the kits out before you and start looking for patterns. Label each piece of information with the participant's name, as well as the where and when of the data.
- Engage your participants in an ideation session based on their insights. This often works well as a group activity, and you can use different ideation techniques that you would typically use with your design team. By now, your participants will be more sensitive to their context, thoughts and feelings thanks to the probes. Remember to include materials from the probes, such as pictures, drawings and quotes, in your sessions.
- Start a discussion with your participants. Ask them what they think of the ideas they've generated and how and why an idea might help them in the future. Ensure you understand your participants' motivations and reasoning by the end of the discussion.

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Stage 3: Communicate Your Findings

- Analyze your findings from the probes as well as your ideation session and discussion. There is no set method for doing, this but look through all the material you have and see which patterns emerge and which ideas they spark.
- Communicate your findings to stakeholders. Describe the ideas you've generated and what insights the ideas are based on. You can create deliverables such as storyboards, user journey maps or personas to help communicate more clearly.
- Use your findings as a basis to turn your ideas into concrete concepts together with your stakeholders.

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